a “state of limbo and drift.”[225] The ambassador noted that the US and India had a “tendency to place [the] worst possible construction on [the] other’s acts of commission or omission.” This tendency was only reinforced by Delhi’s postcrisis conviction that the overall American objective—in collusion with China and Pakistan—was to contain India. After the war, the Soviet Union enjoyed an enhanced position in India since it was seen as having stood by an India faced with a potential two-front war. On the other hand, the US—traditionally the country India had looked to for aid against China—had left India without support.[226]

Indian officials, including Gandhi, did “welcome efforts to make a new start” but made clear that “the ball was in the US court.”[227] Meanwhile, their first major foreign policy step in 1972 was to upgrade relations with North Vietnam. This was something Soviet officials had again requested in discussions with Indian officials during the war about the support they would provide. However, since this step had earlier been “deferred out of deference to US sensitivities,” contemporary observers saw it as retaliation for Washington’s actions during the war.[228]

On the US side, there was agreement that India would be open to an improvement later in the year. Keating believed there would be limits to Soviet influence in India—partly because neither the Soviet Union nor India would meet the other’s expectations.[229] Rogers, too, predicted that to offset its “increased indebtedness to the Soviet Union”—the “price” of its victory—India would “try to restore more balanced relations with Moscow, Peking, and Washington over time.”[230] The NSC staff noted that, while exploiting the Soviet need for India in its effort to contain China, “India will also presumably continue to have some interest in a reasonable relationship with the US as a balance and even in lessening the strain in its relations with China.”[231]

Soviet influence in India, nonetheless, was a matter of concern to some US officials. Keating argued that the US should remain involved in and with India—not just to limit the Soviet role in India by providing an alternative but also to limit the “spoiler” role that India could play vis-à-vis US interests in Asia.[232] The NSC staff also laid down this reason to improve relations with India: it was in US interests to see the Soviet thrust in India blunted. Since Moscow’s relationship with India was “motivated by the containment of China as much as anything,” the NSC felt that China, too,